

piracy, economy packs and budget games are being introduced by local distributors. Such offers compete with pirated wares on price.

Several budget titles have been released by these firms. As an example, Amit says, "e-xpress offers budget titles in the form of two ranges called the Best Seller Series from Vivendi and e-ntertainment series from e-xpress. Both are priced at Rs 499, at present. We also offer a big range of edutainment software (such as *Jumpstart*, *Barbie*, *Fisher Price*, *Playzone*) from Vivendi, at a price range of Rs 299 to Rs 699." Milestone Interactive has a similar range of affordable products—from the Rs 199 'Budget hits', to the Rs 499 'Best of Milestone'—with the reasoning that good titles at digestible prices are bound to sell well.

Send in the consoles! Online gaming too...

The high cost of purchasing a personal computer has led to a PC penetration that is miniscule in comparison to our neighbouring countries. "Publishers are keen on India as a market," says Sachin, "primarily because other markets are akin to smoothly running machines. They have the necessary presence to operate these markets, at an optimal level for maximising revenues. There is a lot of interest in the Asia-Pacific region. Publishers want to know both the nature and the destination

Onimusha, *Final Fantasy X*, *Mortal Kombat Deadly Alliance*, *Metal Gear Solid 2*, give you reason enough to go out there and get a PlayStation 2." He also cites the nature of the hardware involved: "Many gamers are switching over to consoles because the hardware is a one-time buy. You don't have to keep downloading patches to ensure that your games stay bug-free. Two words—No Troubleshooting. Just pop in the DVDROM and enjoy the ride; bye-bye hardware incompatibility issues."

Gaming consoles are not officially available in India (although an official launch of both the Sony PlayStation2 and Microsoft's Xbox is rumoured to be close at hand). The current installed base is expected to be in the range of 2,00,000 units—comprising largely of Sony PSOne and Sega Genesis. According to Amit, "At present, pirated software for consoles is available from Rs 40 to Rs 100. This is really killing the growth of software for consoles in India. Further, duty on console software is increasing its cost. Though we do hope to see some action from console manufacturers in the future." Of course, gamers such as Sriram decide to stick to the tried and tested PC: "A PC is a cheaper gaming solution, and it's also customisable, so a person can invest as much as he wants on turning his PC into a gaming machine. Knowing how Microsoft and Sony are, I have very little hope for console gaming in India. Even if Microsoft and Sony bring their consoles to India, they will have to price it very cheaply to influence the value-conscious Indian."

As far as online gaming is concerned, the lack of broadband access, is proving to be a major stumbling block in the growing popularity of multiplayer games. But gamers have found a way and a few initiatives have been set up to encourage the formation of online communities. A few examples are, Kawabonka.com—an online game server—and the cyber-cafes Skirmish in Mumbai and Surf's Up! in Pune. Sriram is optimistic about the multiplayer scene, "I went to the RAIT college in Mumbai to see the engineering students playing *Quake III Arena* on Linux



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We are confident that 2003 will be the turning point for the Indian games industry, its perception within and outside India

with a keyboard... they were really enjoying it. I have seen more than 50 gamers playing intense clan matches at Surf's Up! There's Kawabonka.com and FragShack, and dozens of other cyber-cafes where kids play *Counter-Strike* and other FPS games." Also, with the entry of players such as Reliance—which is planning to set up multiplayer gaming centres on a fibre-optic backbone—the area of multiplayer gaming is all set to receive a boost.

Public awareness and perception of games is another hurdle. This is bound to change as large players begin to enter the industry. A case in point is Times Multimedia, which uses its media-might to advertise the game titles that it sells. Large publicity campaigns make all the difference as far as sales of entertainment products, such as games are concerned. e-xpress Interactive has, "approached gaming cafes, organised college events, placed specialised merchandising units in retail outlets, and offers have been given to customers in association with national retail chains such as PlanetM and Crossword," says Amit to grant greater visibility to games. As Sachin puts it, "Visibility is paramount but the nature of it comes into question. We try to participate in some college events and such, but it isn't a priority, because the brand recall in such scenarios is not much. We, thus, focus on getting a strong market presence. Our target audience is more likely to walk into a store to make a purchase, and that is where we plan the greatest visibility. Vinyl displays, oversized boxes, and such are used to highlight our offerings."

Rampant piracy? Check. Low sales of legal games? Check. Costly hardware? Check. Non-existent broadband connections? Check. Parents? Of course. A bleak outlook? Nah! Gaming in India is like a toddler—give it the space to crawl—a few bruises and pretty soon it will grow up to be a force to reckon with. ■

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The interactive entertainment industry can be a big market in India, but we need to do a lot of work to create domestic demand and raise market awareness

of this market. Obviously, sheer numbers make this country look impressive, but PC penetration makes, say, China look more attractive to business. We are trying to get everything into place, so that when India comes under the spotlight we are ready. Things will happen."

Veteran gamers are fleeing to greener pastures. Some like Gagan Gupta have found love in the arms of a console. "PC gaming used to rock about a few years back, it is now stale and repetitive, with no real innovation. Games such as, *Devil May Cry*,